

GNUKhata: Made-for-India Accounting Software

This article turns the spotlight on an inspiring FOSS project developed in India. GNUKhata is an accounting application that holds its own against popular proprietary variants, and can also be used by the visually impaired. The driving force behind the project is a visionary who lost his sight himself.



GNUKhata founder Krishnakant Mane (extreme left) and lead developer Prajкта Patkar (standing) explain the software at a recent event in Goa

Krishnakant Mane, 37, needs quite a bit of help to navigate his way through Panaji, the small capital of Goa located along the banks of the Mandovi river. It is usually very easy to find your way there; if nothing else, the river guides you. But, as Mane told me later when we got a chance to speak, “I’m completely blind.”

When it comes to crafting software, however, Krishnakant, who is called just KK in FOSS circles, finds his way around with ease. He is, in fact, the father of GNUKhata, the made-for-India, open source “free and flexible software for accounting and inventory management.”

On his website, KK says, “Vision is important, more than sight. Knowledge is important, more than information.” His site is part of his work at the Digital Freedom Foundation, which he set up.

As he explains, digital freedom is fundamental to life. So the foundation he launched works on “bringing

freedom of technology in education.” Besides “advocacy based on free software,” it takes up projects linked to rural digital empowerment, and ICT based infrastructure in the rural parts of India. All of this is based exclusively on using free and open source software. The foundation also actively participates in developing FOSS tools in the education, health and finance sectors. Check out more about it at <http://dff.org.in/>.

GNUKhata is one of the tools developed by KK’s foundation. Like some other fairly innovative Indian FOSS products, GNUKhata probably hasn’t been sufficiently noticed in the land it was born in. But it is making impressive progress now.

In Panaji, on a social visit recently, literally leading KK around the city was Prajкта Patkar, the project manager of GNUKhata software (both work together on the project with others). Not one to waste time, KK got in touch

and offered to speak while on his trip. In a short while, their laptops were set up and they were ready to demo the fruits of their work.

Flawlessly, Patkar and KK got into explaining mode. There was an audience of techies, FOSS enthusiasts, and accountants or businessmen. Each one had come with their own interests in mind, and they didn’t go home disappointed.

GNUKhata is growing steadily. As I was completing this write-up, it was announced that GNUKhata version 5.10 has been released (in mid-June 2018). Version 5 was itself a major release. This latest version has a redesigned user interface. “These changes will help you manage the business with great ease, even if you are a non-accountant,” a GNUKhata announcement that reached my mailbox stated. The helpdesk is at support.gnukhata.in and the mailing list is on freelists.org

Of late, the project has got support from the International Center for FOSS (ICFOSS). This is the Kerala government’s autonomous institution that has been set up to coordinate FOSS initiatives within Kerala. ICFOSS has also been tasked with linking up with initiatives in other parts of the globe “to push the agenda of promoting democratic access to information and knowledge through equitable modes of production and distribution of software and knowledge.” GNUKhata also gets support from the consultative firm Tech Blue Inc.

With the dedicated, hard work of the team and support from others, GNUKhata has grown a lot.